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HEIRSTONE CONSULTING RESEARCH | 2026

MEETINGS AND CONVENTIONS IN AFRICA

The price of a plenary seat

What international meetings are worth to an African capital, and what a convention centre has to carry to win them



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THE REPORT IN SIX NUMBERS

2 to 3%

Africa's share of the 12,438 international association meetings ICCA counted worldwide in its 2025 rankings, roughly 250 to 370 meetings a year

US$115k

complex cost per plenary seat at Kigali: US$300m for the 2,600-seat convention centre, a 292-room hotel and an office park

15x

FY2023/24 EBITDA: the multiple implied by Cape Town's R885m desktop valuation of its 72.7% CTICC stake, or about US$69m for the whole company pro rata

11x

revenue per international event against revenue per national event at Durban ICC in FY2021/22 and FY2022/23, the last two years reported

38

international delegates per "international conference" in Kenya in 2024, against 717 delegates per ICCA meeting in Cape Town

49,704

final attendance at COP27, Sharm El Sheikh, 2022: the largest COP to that date, and 1.2 times all delegates at Cape Town's 58 ICCA meetings in 2024

CONTENTS

	Summary	3
1	A small market, counted three ways	4
2	What a meeting pays	7
3	Who carries the building	9
4	The Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark	13
5	The constraint outside the hall	16
6	North Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa	21
7	What each party should do	25
	Notes, sources and definitions	27

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is written for governments, investment promotion agencies, tourism authorities and convention bureaus, for venue owners, hotel investors and lenders, and for the boards of companies and institutions that hold meetings in Africa. It draws on public sources current in 2026: venue annual reports, Kenya's Auditor-General, convention bureau releases, ICCA and UNFCCC data as reported, World Bank and AfDB statistics, and the Brookings Institution's work on US convention centres.

Where we have combined published figures to produce a new one, such as cost per seat, rooms per seat or revenue per event, the calculation is shown and labelled Heirstone analysis. Local-currency figures carry a US$ equivalent at the rate and date given in the notes. Where a figure could not be verified we say so rather than estimate it.

SUMMARY

Capitals win international meetings with air links, open borders and hotel rooms. The convention centre comes after those, and does not recover its cost.

Africa hosts a few hundred international association meetings a year and a handful of cities win most of them. Its newest flagship complexes cost US$80,000 to US$115,000 per plenary seat, offices and hotels included; the best documented African convention business is valued at a fraction of that. A hall pays back through its share of international events and through spending in its city, so the decisions that matter most are made outside it.

1 **The market is small and concentrated.**

ICCA counted 12,438 international association meetings in its 2025 rankings and puts Africa at 2 to 3%, roughly 250 to 370 meetings; South Africa hosted 98 in 2024. Kenya's 987 "international conferences" of 2024 averaged about 38 international delegates, against 717 per ICCA meeting in Cape Town.

2 **International events are where a venue earns.**

At Durban ICC an international event earned about 11 times the revenue of a national one in FY2021/22 and FY2022/23. In the later year 22 international events, one in twenty, earned 36% of event revenue.

3 **Buildings cost far more than the business is worth.**

The Kigali complex, with its hotel and offices, cost US$300m for 2,600 seats; the AU centre US$200m for 2,500. Cape Town's valuation of its CTICC stake implies about US$69m for the whole company: 15 times FY2023/24 EBITDA, under a quarter of Kigali's cost.

4 **Public owners carry costs outside operating results.**

Durban ICC went from a R43m profit to a R63.8m loss in FY2017/18 after a R57.6m rates-linked impairment of its building. KICC's receivables overdue by over three years, mostly from ministries, were KES 623m in FY2018/19, about 61% of revenue, according to Kenya's Auditor-General.

5 **The binding constraints sit outside the hall.**

COP27 brought 49,704 people to Sharm El Sheikh; Africa's largest verified plenary holds over 4,000. Kigali's attached hotel offers 0.11 rooms per plenary seat. Cairo, Africa's busiest airport, and Casablanca reach four to five times Kigali's 26 destinations; Kigali, ranked second in Africa, admits all Africans visa-free.

6 **No city we tested passes all five Host City Test gates.**

On public evidence Cape Town and Nairobi pass three. The gate most cities cannot evidence at all is hotel rooms within reach of the plenary.

WHAT IT MEANS

Governments should run a host city test before commissioning a hall, open visas first and price the full public cost of the building, land and rates included.

Convention bureaus should report international delegate-days and the share of international events alongside any count of conferences.

Venue owners and lenders should separate ownership of the building from its operation and underwrite on international share.

Hotel investors should size rooms from a venue's forward book of delegate-days and treat summit peaks as one-offs.

20

venues in the Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark, drawn from a register of 31 named African venues

3

of those 31 venues have operating results in the public domain: CTICC, Durban ICC and, through Kenya's Auditor-General, KICC

CHAPTER 1



01

A small market, counted three ways

ICCA counts association meetings that rotate between countries. National statistics count conferences of any size. Summit hosts count everyone with a badge. Each number answers a different question, and a venue plan needs to know which one it is using.

ICCA, the association-meetings industry body, counted 12,438 international association meetings worldwide in its 2025 rankings, up from almost 10,000 in its 2023 report. A meeting qualifies only if it rotates between at least three countries and draws at least 50 delegates. ICCA's African Chapter page gives Africa's share as about 2% in one passage and 3% in another. On the 2025 total, that is roughly 250 to 370 meetings a year for a continent of 54 countries.

ICCA keeps country and city counts behind a member wall, and ICCA itself has members in only 11 countries in Southern, East and West Africa. African figures reach the public when a convention bureau chooses to release them.

South Africa hosted 98 qualifying meetings in 2023 and again in 2024, up from 84 in 2021. Cape Town hosted 42 in 2023 and 58 in 2024; the Western Cape bureau reported 55 in the 2025 rankings, in a release that dates them to 2024. Kigali ranked second in Africa for a fifth year in the 2024 rankings; its count is not published.

South Africa's 98 meetings equal between a quarter and two-fifths of the estimated African total. Most of the rest of the market cannot be seen from outside ICCA's membership, which matters for anyone writing a business case: most bids quote ICCA rankings that the bidder cannot verify in detail.

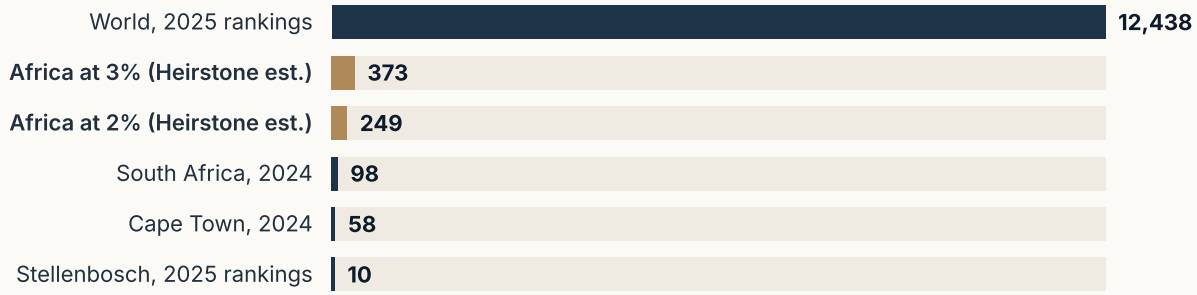
DEFINITIONS

An "international conference" in Nairobi and an ICCA congress in Cape Town are different products

EXHIBIT 1

Africa hosts perhaps 250 to 370 of the world's 12,438 rotating association meetings

International association meetings meeting ICCA criteria, latest public counts; Africa range at 2% and 3% of the 2025 world total



Source: ICCA, GlobeWatch Country and City Rankings 2025 release and African Chapter page (accessed 2026); IOL, 4 June 2025, quoting Wesgro and ICCA; Wesgro, 21 May 2026. **Heirstone analysis.** South Africa and Cape Town counts are 2024; the world total is 2025.

Kenya's Tourism Research Institute publishes a national conference series. It counted 987 international conferences in 2024 with 37,405 international delegates, an average of about 38 each. In the same year Kenya hosted 11,225 local conferences with 699,469 delegates, so local delegates outnumbered international ones by about 19 to 1.

Business and conference travellers were 643,595, or 26.9%, of Kenya's international arrivals in 2024. South Africa's statistics office counts on a different basis: only 209,492 foreign tourists, 2.0% of the total, gave business as their main purpose in 2019, because its "holiday" category is broad.

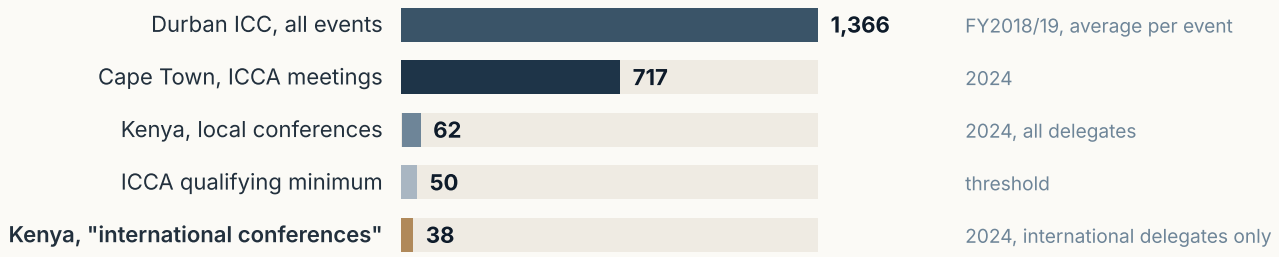
The planning consequence is direct. In Kenya's figures the local layer is more than eleven times larger by count, with local conferences averaging about 62 delegates. A capital's convention centre lives day to day on domestic and government meetings, and international association congresses of several hundred delegates are a thin, contested layer on top.

The two layers need different buildings. Plenary halls should be sized to the association layer. Meeting rooms and flat floor should be sized to the local base, and plans should state which definition every demand figure uses.

EXHIBIT 2

An "international conference" in Kenya averaged 38 international delegates; an ICCA meeting in Cape Town averaged 717

Average delegates per meeting or event under five definitions



Source: Durban ICC Annual Report 2019; IOL, 4 June 2025, quoting Wesgro and ICCA; Tourism Research Institute (Kenya), Tourism Sector Performance Report 2024; Wesgro citing ICCA, 21 May 2026. **Heirstone analysis** for Kenya averages (delegates divided by conferences).

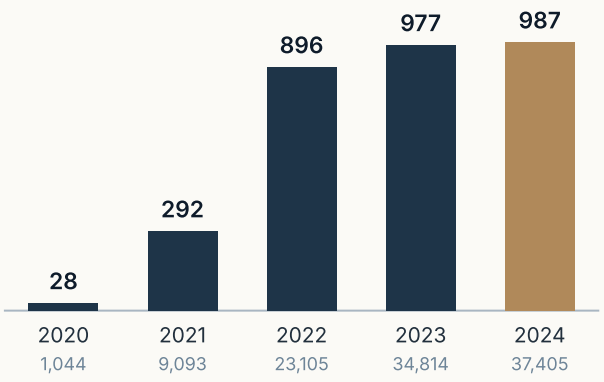
SCALE

One climate summit brought more people to Sharm El Sheikh than a year of association congresses brought to Cape Town

EXHIBIT 3

Kenya's international conference count has levelled off near 1,000 a year

International conferences hosted in Kenya (bars) and international delegates (below), 2020 to 2024



Source: Tourism Research Institute (Kenya), Tourism Sector Performance Report 2024 (February 2025).

Kenya's count recovered from 28 international conferences in 2020 to 896 in 2022 and then rose only 1% in 2024, to 987. International delegates still grew 7.4% that year, so the average meeting grew while their number barely moved.

Mega-events are a separate business. COP27 recorded 33,449 provisionally registered participants and a final attendance of 49,704, 49% more, which made it the largest COP to that date. The provisional list included 16,118 party delegates, 11,711 NGO observers and 3,350 media; Egypt's own delegation, 155, was its largest at a COP to that date. Any per-delegate impact claim for a summit has to say which of those figures it uses.

For a venue, the more useful distinction is between one-off and recurring demand. Mining Indaba, according to its organiser, brings 12,000 or more delegates to the CTICC every February, and the Africa Energy Forum met there in June 2026; a COP or a heads-of-government meeting comes once. Recurring events of this kind give a hall its base load, and summits come on top of it.

1.2x

COP27's attendance relative to all delegates at Cape Town's 58 ICCA meetings in 2024

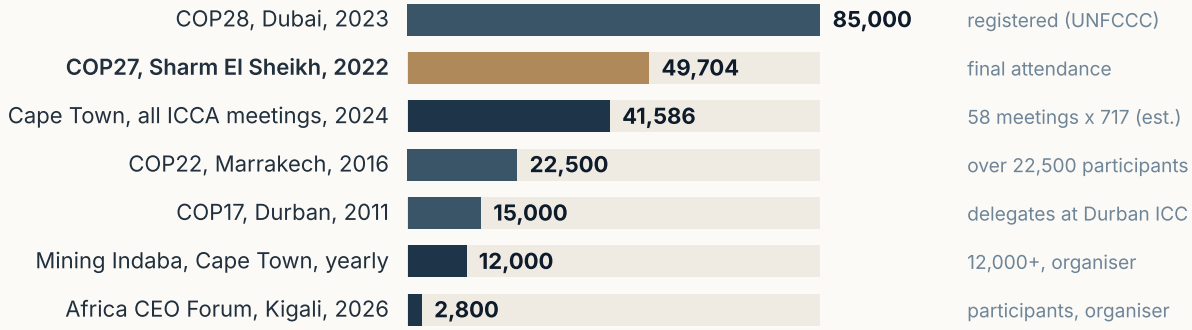
12,000+

delegates that Mining Indaba brings to the CTICC each year, according to its organiser

EXHIBIT 4

One COP can outdraw a year of Cape Town's association meetings, but it does not return

Participants at selected meetings held in or near African venues, with COP28 for comparison; latest available edition



Source: Carbon Brief, COP27 delegates analysis (UNFCCC data); UNFCCC, COP28 key takeaways; IISD Earth Negotiations Bulletin, COP22 summary (2016); Durban ICC Annual Report 2012; Mining Indaba and Africa CEO Forum websites; IOL, 4 June 2025. **Heirstone analysis** for Cape Town (58 meetings x 717 average delegates).

CHAPTER 2

02

What a meeting pays

Two South African municipal venues, the CTICC in Cape Town and Durban ICC, publish annual reports detailed enough to show how a convention centre makes money. Durban's show that international events earn about eleven times as much per event as national ones; Cape Town's show a recovery built on yield. The economic impact figures in the same reports measure something else.

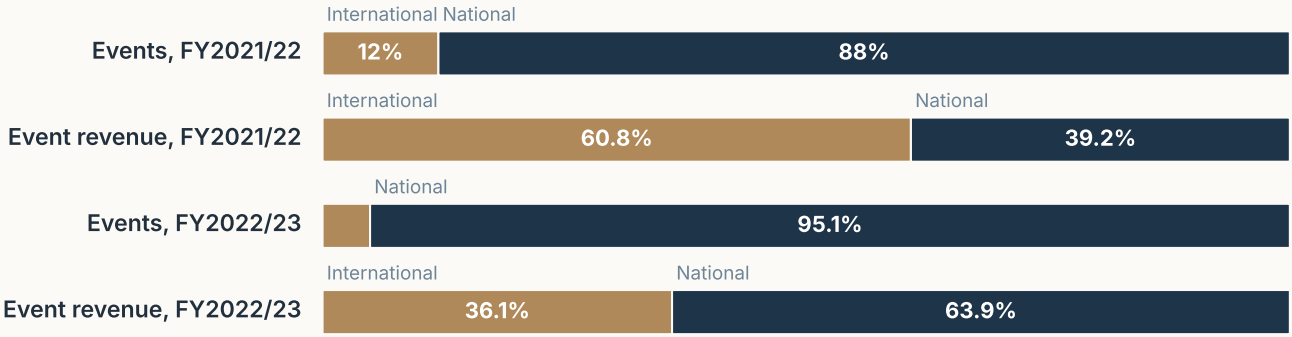
Durban ICC splits its event revenue between international and national events. In FY2021/22 its 31 international events earned R55.3m, about R1.78m each, while 228 national events earned R35.6m, or R0.16m each: a ratio of 11.4 to 1. In FY2022/23 the 22 international events averaged R2.64m (about US$139,000) and the 426 national events R0.24m (about US$12,700), a ratio of 11.0 to 1.

The business case for a convention centre therefore rests on its share of international rotations, and that share moves sharply. Durban hosted 109 international events out of 547 in FY2016/17, 29 out of 444 in FY2018/19 and none in FY2020/21. A business plan should test its case at the low end of that range.

EXHIBIT 5

At Durban ICC, one event in twenty brought in more than a third of event revenue

International and national events: share of events and share of event revenue, Durban ICC, years to 30 June



Source: Durban ICC, Annual Reports 2022 and 2023. **Heirstone analysis.** International events were 12% of events and 61% of event revenue in FY2021/22, and 5% and 36% in FY2022/23. Event revenue excludes other income.

11.0x

revenue per international event over a national one at Durban ICC in FY2022/23: R2.64m against R0.24m

109 to 0

international events at Durban ICC in FY2016/17 and in FY2020/21, the first full COVID year

R8.5m

net foreign exchange per international event at Durban in FY2022/23 (R186.5m over 22 events, BDO assessment)

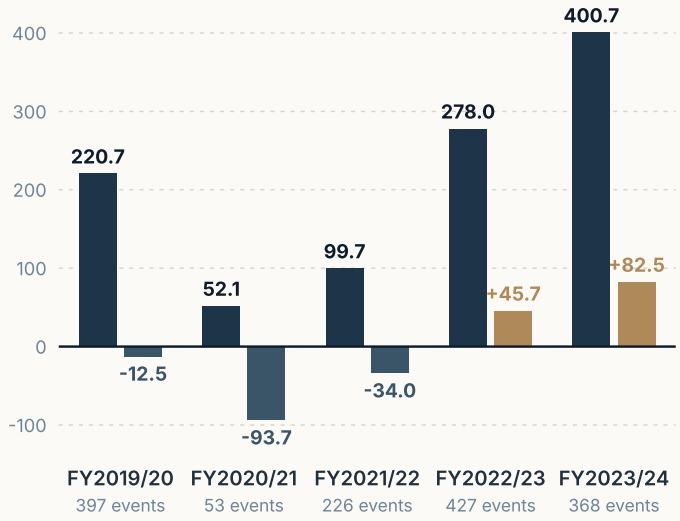
YIELD AND IMPACT

Cape Town's recovery came from yield per event. The impact figures come from a spending model.

EXHIBIT 6

CTICC moved from an R93.7m EBITDA loss to an R82.5m profit in three years

CTICC revenue including other income (navy) and EBITDA (gold or slate), R million, years to 30 June; FY2021/22 EBITDA is adjusted



Source: CTICC Integrated Annual Reports 2019/20 and 2022; CTICC AGM releases of 25 January 2022, 19 February 2024 and 27 January 2025.

CTICC hosted 397 events in FY2019/20 and 368 in FY2023/24, yet revenue nearly doubled. Revenue per event rose from R0.56m to R1.09m, and revenue grew 44% in the final year alone while event numbers fell. International events rose 30.3% to 43. In US$, FY2023/24 revenue was about US$22.0m and EBITDA about US$4.5m, a margin of 20.6%.

The budgets show what the owners expect. CTICC targeted an EBITDA loss of R23.6m for FY2019/20 and budgeted a loss of R91.4m for FY2021/22: a public venue is allowed to lose money on operations. In January 2025 its forward book held close to 400 events to FY2029/30, about 20% of them international, valued at about R1.5bn.

EBITDA leaves out depreciation of the buildings, so even a positive result does not show the full public cost. Chapter 3 returns to that.

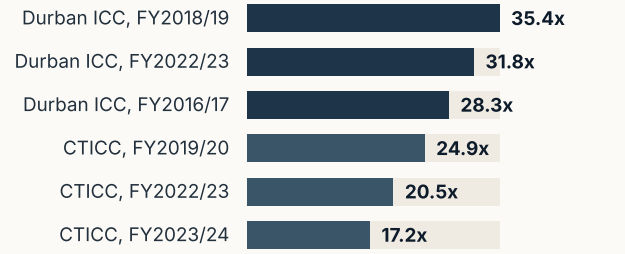
Both venues publish a contribution to GDP each year, and those figures run at 17 to 35 times venue revenue. They are gross spending models commissioned by the venues: Durban has commissioned one every year since 2007 and does not publish its per-delegate spend assumptions.

The cumulative series also need care. At the CTICC's opening in 2003, a study projected R25bn of GDP and 47,000 jobs over ten years. The cumulative claim reached R54.3bn by FY2021/22, R60bn by 2023 and R66.9bn in the City's 2025 statement. Cumulative jobs rose from 115,000+ in July 2019 to 143,282 two years later, across one year that reported 11,861 jobs and one in which the venue was largely closed. The rand lost about 20% of its dollar value between mid-2019 and mid-2025, so rand growth overstates dollar growth.

EXHIBIT 7

Venues report GDP contributions of 17 to 35 times their own revenue

Claimed contribution to national GDP divided by venue revenue, same year



Source: CTICC and Durban ICC annual reports and AGM releases. **Heirstone analysis.**

R27,600

expected impact per delegate (about US$1,550) implied by the Cape Town bureau's 36 bids in FY2024/25: 27,000+ delegates and R745m. Bureau budgets can be judged against it.

US$1.08m

average direct impact per government meeting in ICCA's 2025 report (US$2.5bn over 2,324 meetings), a benchmark for intergovernmental events

CHAPTER 3

03

Who carries the building

Construction, expansion or renovation costs are public for six of the 31 venues in our register. Operating results are public for three.

Several of Africa's flagship halls were built for a particular summit, paid for by a state or a donor government or held by a public pension fund, and then had to find a market. The capital decision is the largest in the meetings business and the least disclosed.

CICAD at Diamniadio was inaugurated for the Francophonie Summit in 2014. The African Union's conference centre, a US$200m gift from the Chinese government, opened in 2012 during an AU summit. The Kigali Convention Centre was due for completion three years after 2009; it opened in 2016, in time for that year's AU Summit. JNICC in Dar es Salaam, a Chinese government grant, was completed in 2012.

Kigali's owner of record is Ultimate Concepts Ltd, a joint venture including the government, and the Rwanda Social Security Board lists the centre among the flagship assets of its real estate book of RWF 351bn (about US$242m), spread over 15 or more properties and equal to 9% of its assets. The financing terms are not published. We found no published utilisation or revenue target for any of these halls.



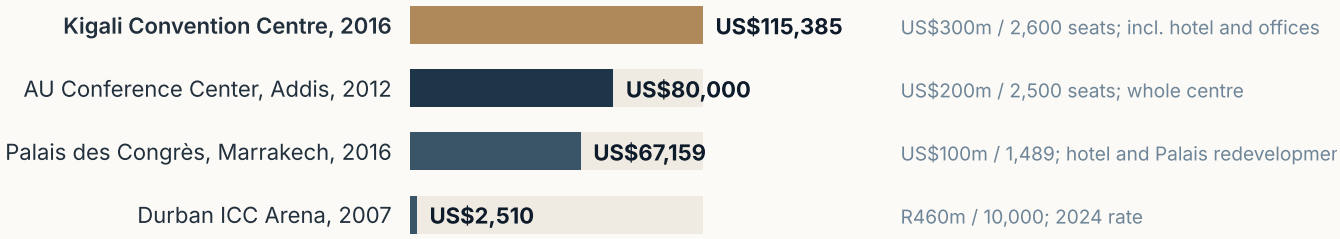
CAPITAL COST

Africa's newest flagship complexes cost US$80,000 to US$115,000 per plenary seat; the best documented operating business is worth far less

EXHIBIT 8

Prestige halls cost 27 to 46 times as much per seat as Durban's flat-floor arena

Reported construction or redevelopment cost divided by largest-room capacity, US$ per seat; scopes and years differ



Source: KT Press (2016) and AIPC member profile (Kigali); African Union, inauguration release (2012); Mövenpick Hotels & Resorts (2016); Sowetan (2007); World Bank WDI PA.NUS.FCRF, 2024 average exchange rate for ZAR. **Heirstone analysis.** Costs are nominal and not inflation-adjusted. The rand cost is converted at the 2024 rate, not the build-year rate.

The comparison is rough. Kigali's figure includes a 292-room hotel and an office park; the AU's covers the whole centre; Marrakech's covers the redevelopment of a hotel and congress complex. The direction is still clear, and so is the contrast with flat floor: Durban's arena cost R46,000 a seat at its audience capacity of 10,000, about US$2,500 at 2024 rates, roughly one forty-fifth of Kigali's complex cost per seat. Divisible halls with temporary seating buy capacity far more cheaply than a fixed prestige auditorium.

In August 2025 the City of Cape Town proposed selling its 72.7% stake in the CTICC at a desktop valuation of about R885m, keeping the land. Pro rata, that implies R1,217m, about US$68.6m, for the whole company: 3.0 times FY2023/24 revenue and 14.8 times EBITDA. The gap between what governments spend to build and what the operating business is worth is the public's contribution. It is recovered, if at all, through spending in the city.

EXHIBIT 9

Cape Town's own valuation puts the CTICC company at under a quarter of the Kigali complex's build cost

Build or redevelopment cost, and implied equity value of the CTICC operating company, US$ million



Source: KT Press (2016); African Union (2012); Construction Kenya (2025, grade C); Mövenpick Hotels & Resorts (2016); IOL Weekend Argus (2025); CTICC FY2023/24 AGM release. **Heirstone analysis.** CTICC value at R17.757 per US$ (30 June 2025); Bomas at the 2024 average rate. Values and costs are different measures.

Nairobi's planned Bomas International Convention Complex would join KICC, a state-owned hall with a plenary for over 4,000. According to Construction Kenya, Turkey's Summa won the KSh 31.6bn tender for a conference centre and at least five luxury hotels; seats, timetable and financing could not be verified. A second state flagship in the same city needs a demand test that the public record does not yet show.

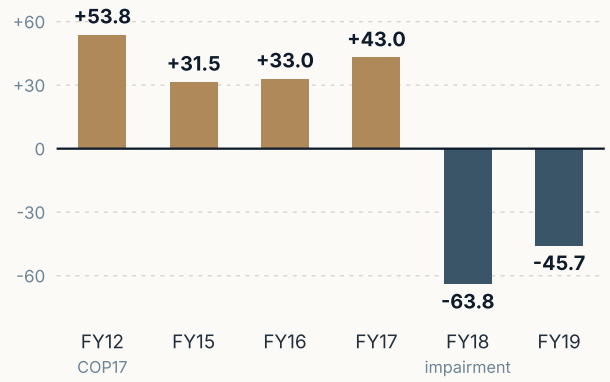
OPERATING RESULTS

For public venues, property costs and slow-paying government clients weigh on results

EXHIBIT 10

Durban ICC moved into loss after a rates-linked impairment of its building

Durban ICC net profit or loss after tax, R million, years to 30 June (FY12 = FY2011/12)



Source: Durban ICC Annual Reports 2012, 2015, 2017, 2018 and 2019. FY2015/16 figure as restated in the 2017 report.

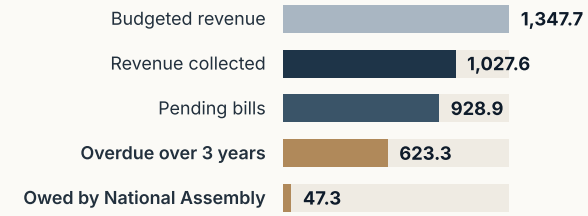
Durban ICC made a net profit in each reported year to FY2016/17. In FY2017/18 it lost R63.8m on revenue of R168.4m, driven by a R57.6m impairment of the building after an increase in municipal rates reduced its expected cash flows. In the same year it received R8.15m of government grants, including eThekwini grants towards building rates. Depreciation and amortisation rose from R16.1m to R52.1m.

In FY2018/19 the operating deficit was R53.76m, almost exactly the depreciation and amortisation charge of R52.09m: before those charges the deficit was about R1.7m. The net loss was about US$3.2m. The building is owned by eThekwini Municipality, which levies the rates and in FY2017/18 also granted the venue part of their cost.

EXHIBIT 11

KICC's receivables overdue by more than three years equalled 61% of its FY2018/19 revenue

KICC revenue, payables and receivables, KES million, FY2018/19



Source: Office of the Auditor-General (Kenya), Report on the financial statements of KICC for FY2018/19; the auditor states that the bulk of the overdue amount is owed by government ministries and departments. **Heirstone analysis** for ratios.

KICC was taken over by the Government of Kenya in 2003 and became a state corporation in 2004. In FY2018/19 it collected KES 1,027.6m (about US$10.1m), 24% short of budget. The Auditor-General reported receivables of KES 623.3m (about US$6.1m) outstanding for more than three years, the bulk of them owed by government ministries and departments. The audit opinion for that year was qualified, as were those for FY2021/22 and FY2022/23.

Pending bills of KES 928.9m at 30 June 2019 equalled about 90% of the year's revenue, and the National Assembly owed a further KES 47.3m. Government bodies are both KICC's owner and among its clients, so the timing of their payments feeds directly into its cash position.

THE US RECORD, FOR COMPARISON

The Brookings Institution's 2005 study by Heywood Sanders found that US convention exhibit space grew 51% between 1990 and 2003, from 40.4m to 60.9m sq ft, while public capital spending doubled from US$1.2bn to US$2.4bn a year. Attendance at the 200 largest trade shows peaked at 5.1m in 1996 and fell to 4.1m in 2003. Washington DC's US$834m centre was forecast to lose US$16.2m in 2004/05 on top of US$36.2m of debt service, about US$52.4m a year. Cities then subsidised headquarters hotels, such as St Louis's 1,081-room, US$265m Renaissance with US$80m of city aid, and a Dallas proposal offered rebates of US$5 per room-night. The data are two decades old, and Africa's current build-out could repeat the sequence.

OWNERSHIP

Six ways African convention centres are owned, and where each puts the risk

The venues in our register fall into six ownership models. The model decides who pays for the building, who runs it, what is disclosed and who absorbs a weak year. It also decides what a government can change later: a donor-built hall has no investor to bring discipline, while a hotel-anchored venue answers first to the hotel's room nights.

Only the first model publishes the operating and impact data a lender or a ministry of finance would expect. KICC, a Kenyan state corporation, is visible through the Auditor-General. For the rest, including every francophone and North African venue in the register, we found neither operating results nor utilisation figures.

1 of 6

ownership models in which venues publish annual operating results and impact studies

EXHIBIT 12

Who funds, runs and reports: the six models in the register

Ownership models of African convention venues, with examples and the main risk each carries

	MODEL	EXAMPLES	FUNDS THE BUILDING	RUNS IT	PUBLISHED	MAIN RISK
1	**Municipal or provincial company**	CTICC (City of Cape Town 72.7%, Western Cape 22.2%, SunWest 5.1%); Durban ICC (eThekwini Municipality)	City and province	Venue company	Annual reports, operating results, impact studies	Property costs and rates land on the venue; impact claims carry the case
2	**State corporation**	KICC (state corporation since 2004); Bomas complex, Nairobi (planned, tendered by the state)	National budget	State corporation	Auditor-General reports (Kenya); otherwise little	Overdue receivables from government clients; qualified audits; duplication within one city
3	**Donor-built hall**	AU Conference Center (US$200m, a Chinese government gift); JNICC Dar es Salaam (Chinese government grant, completed 2012)	Foreign government	Host institution or state	Build cost only	Renovation and upkeep fall to the host
4	**Hotel-anchored private venue**	Eko Convention Centre (824 rooms); Sandton (Southern Sun); Marrakech Palais (Al Ajial Asset Company, Mövenpick, 503 rooms and suites)	Private owner	Hotel operator	Not reported separately	Venue calendar set by the hotel's room-night needs
5	**Public pension capital**	Kigali Convention Centre (owner Ultimate Concepts Ltd; RSSB flagship investment; Radisson Blu)	Pension fund investment (terms not published)	Hotel operator	None found	Pension members bear any shortfall in the asset's return
6	**Dedicated event site**	Bab Ighli, Marrakech, for COP22; outside Africa, Baku's 112,000 m2 COP29 venue	Event budget	Event organiser	Rarely	One-off cost tied to a single event

Source: Heirstone African convention venue register (31 venues), compiled from venue and operator websites, annual reports, Kenya's Auditor-General and AidData, 2026; Durban ICC and CTICC reports; UNFCCC (COP22); Euronews (COP29, 2024). **Heirstone analysis.**

Two recent arrangements point the same way. Cape Town's proposed stake sale would bring private capital into the operating company while the City keeps the land. Nigeria's Bureau of Public Enterprises lists the Lagos International Trade Fair Complex, 322 hectares commissioned in 1976, for reform by concession rather than sale.

Each separates the owner of the building from the operator who has to fill it. That separation is the condition for the disclosure the other models lack: an operator on a contract reports against targets set by the owner.

CHAPTER 4

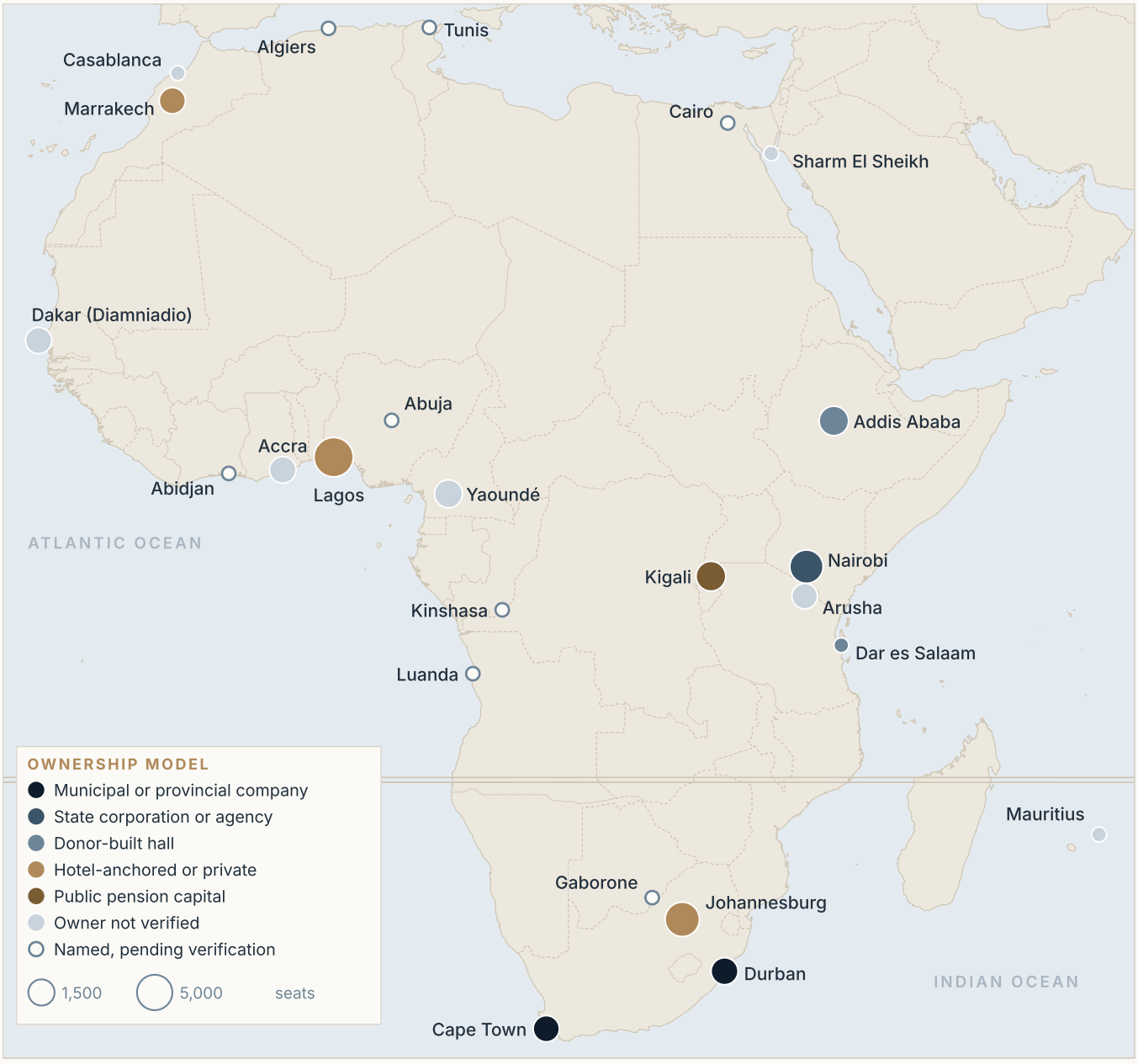
The Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark

We assembled public data on 31 named convention, conference and exhibition venues in 18 African countries. Twenty with at least one verified attribute form the benchmark on the next page: opening year, largest room, cost, cost per seat, attached hotel rooms, ownership, disclosure and the meetings each has hosted. Eight cities in the register, Abidjan, Abuja, Algiers, Cairo, Gaborone, Kinshasa, Luanda and Tunis, are not yet scored, because their venues' specifications could not be confirmed from public sources for this edition.

EXHIBIT 13

Africa's verified halls are spread thinly and owned in very different ways

Benchmark venues by city: circle size scales with the largest verified room or hall; colour shows the ownership model; rings mark cities whose named venue is pending verification



Source: Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark, 2026; Natural Earth; GeoNames gazetteer. All positions are approximate (GeoNames city or locality centres); Dakar stands for Diamniadio and Johannesburg for Sandton.

THE BENCHMARK: TWENTY VENUES, ONE TABLE
EXHIBIT 14

Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark: what is known, and what is not, about Africa's main halls

Largest room in seats unless stated as guests or participants; cost as reported, nominal; cost per seat in US$; rooms per seat = attached hotel rooms divided by largest room

VENUE	OPENED	LARGEST ROOM	REPORTED COST	US$ PER SEAT	ATTACHED ROOMS	ROOMS PER SEAT	OWNERSHIP AND OPERATOR	RESULTS PUBLISHED	NOTABLE MEETINGS
NORTH AFRICA									
Palais des Congrès de Marrakech Marrakech	n/v	1,489	US$100m redevelopment, 2016	67,200*	503	0.34	Hotel-anchored: Al Ajial Asset Company, Mövenpick	None found	Reopened 2016
Bab Ighli event site Marrakech	2016	22,500+ at COP22	n/v				Dedicated event site	None found	COP22, 2016
OFEC fair site Casablanca	n/v	n/v	n/v				n/v	None found	Part to become a congress and exhibition centre (2023 plan)
COP27 venue Sharm El Sheikh	n/v	n/v	n/v		n/v		n/v	None found	COP27, 2022
EAST AFRICA									
Kenyatta ICC (KICC) Nairobi	1973	4,000+	n/v		none on site		State corporation since 2004	Auditor-General	WB/IMF Annual Meetings 1973
Bomas complex (planned) Nairobi	planned	n/v	KSh 31.6bn tender (US$234m)		n/v		State tender (Summa)		
Arusha ICC (AICC) Arusha	n/v	1,350	n/v		n/v		n/v	None found	
Julius Nyerere ICC Dar es Salaam	2012	n/v	RMB 183.5m Chinese grant		n/v		State; Chinese grant	None found	
Kigali Convention Centre Kigali	2016	2,600	US$300m (complex)	115,400	292	0.11	Pension capital: RSSB flagship; Radisson Blu	None found	AU Summit 2016; ICCA #2 city in Africa
AU Conference Center Addis Ababa	2012	2,500	US$200m (complex)	80,000	n/a		Donor-built: Chinese gift; AU	None found	AU summits
Africa Hall Addis Ababa	1961	n/v	US$28.2m renovation contract		n/a		UN Economic Commission for Africa	None found	Re-inaugurated 2024
SOUTHERN AFRICA AND INDIAN OCEAN									
CTICC 1 and 2 Cape Town	2003	1,500 (+620)	n/v		n/v		Municipal company	Annual reports	ICCA #1 city; Mining Indaba; AEF
Durban ICC Durban	1997	1,728 (arena to 10,000)	R460m arena (US$25.1m)	2,500*	327	0.19	Municipal entity	Annual reports	CHOGM 1999; COP17 2011; AIDS 2000, 2016
Sandton Convention Centre Johannesburg	n/v	4,500 guests	n/v		9 hotels nearby		Operator: Southern Sun	None found	
Gallagher Convention Centre Midrand	1993	7,000 guests	n/v		n/v		n/v	None found	27 venues on 32 ha
SVICC Pailles, Mauritius	n/v	n/v	n/v		n/v		n/v	None found	17,000 m2 building
WEST AND CENTRAL AFRICA									
CICAD Diamniadio	2014	1,500	n/v		none verified		Delegated owner: APIX	None found	Francophonie Summit 2014
Eko Convention Centre Lagos	n/v	7,000 seats	n/v		824	0.12	Hotel-anchored: Eko Hotels	None found	
Accra ICC Accra	1991	1,600	n/v		n/v		n/v	None found	Built for a 1991 NAM ministerial
Palais des Congrès de Yaoundé Yaoundé	1982	2,000	n/v		n/v		n/v	None found	Rooms of 25 to 2,000 seats

Source: Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark, 2026, compiled from venue and operator websites, annual reports, Kenya's Auditor-General, AidData and the sources in the notes. n/v: not verified; n/a: not applicable. *Hotel and Palais redevelopment (Marrakech) or arena only (Durban, at the 2024 average rate). **Heirstone analysis** for cost per seat and rooms per seat. Also named, pending verification: Hôtel Ivoire, Palais de la Culture de Treichville and Parc des Expositions (Abidjan), International Conference Centre Abuja, Addis International Convention Center, CIC Abdelatif Rahal (Algiers), Cairo International Conference Centre and Egypt International Exhibition Center (Cairo), Gaborone International Convention Centre, Palais du Peuple (Kinshasa), Centro de Convenções de Talatona (Luanda), Palais des Congrès de Tunis.

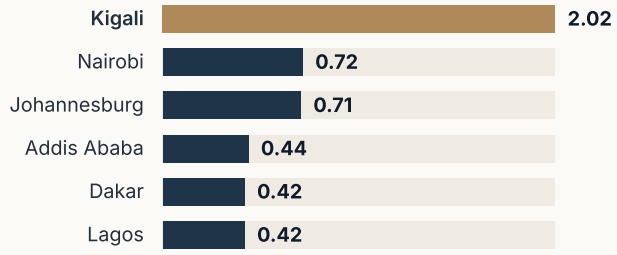
READING THE BENCHMARK

Half the dated flagship halls opened in 1997 or earlier, and Kigali has built nearly five times Lagos's plenary capacity per resident

EXHIBIT 15

Kigali carries about two plenary seats per 1,000 residents, nearly three times Nairobi

Largest verified hall in the largest city, seats or guests per 1,000 residents, 2024



Source: Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark; World Bank WDI EN.URB.LCTY, 2024. **Heirstone analysis.** Cameroon and Ghana are left out because the World Bank series may refer to Douala and Kumasi rather than Yaoundé and Accra.

A big bet on imported demand

Kigali's hall is nearly three times Nairobi's relative to population and four and a half to five times those of Addis Ababa, Dakar and Lagos. A hall that size cannot be filled from its own city, so Rwanda's bid-led strategy is a structural necessity. Small states face the same arithmetic: Mauritius has 2.06 register venues per million urban residents and Botswana 0.59, against 0.014 in Nigeria.

Halls sized for congresses

Most verified plenaries hold about 1,500 to 2,600 seats. Larger numbers are banqueting or flat-floor capacities (Eko, Gallagher, Durban's arena) or a legacy plenary such as KICC's.

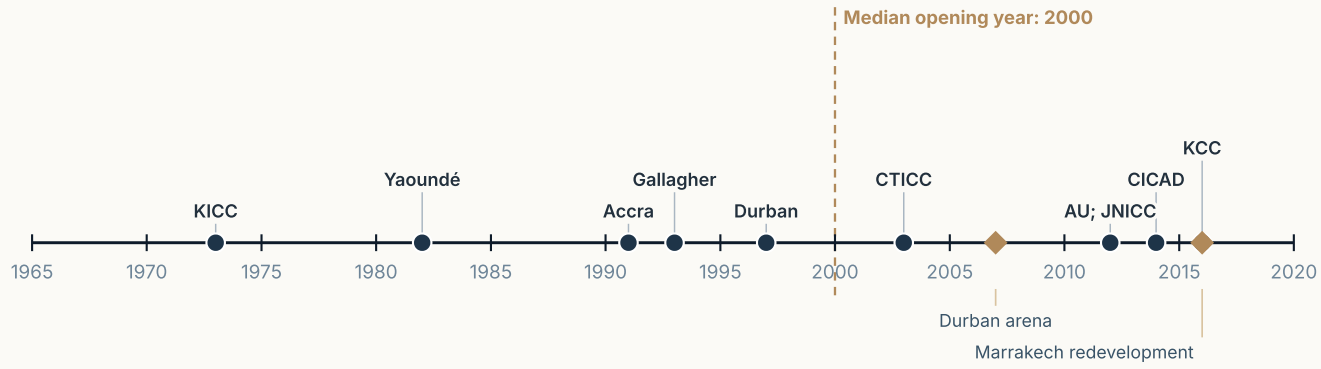
The next capital cycle is renovation

Marrakech's Palais reopened in 2016 after a US$100m redevelopment of its hotel complex, UNECA contracted Africa Hall's renovation at US$28.2m, and part of Casablanca's fair site is to become a congress centre.

EXHIBIT 16

Half of the ten dated flagship venues opened in 1997 or earlier

Opening years of dated venues in the register (above the line) and later extensions or redevelopments (below)



Source: Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark, 2026: KICC; Investir au Cameroun (2016); News Ghana (2026); Gallagher; Durban ICC; CTICC opening address (2003); African Union (2012); AidData; Au Sénégal; KT Press (2016); Mövenpick (2016).

CHAPTER 5

05

The constraint outside the hall

Associations choose cities they can fly to, enter easily and sleep in. The attached hotel covers a small fraction of a full plenary; the rest has to come from the city.

The hotels attached to Africa's halls offer between 0.11 and 0.34 rooms per plenary seat: 292 rooms for Kigali's 2,600 seats, 824 for Eko's 7,000, 327 for Durban's 1,728-seat Hall 1 and 503 for Marrakech's 1,489. Most delegates at a full congress have to stay in other hotels.

Cape Town's bureau counts about 20,000 hotel rooms in the city and about 7,500 within walking distance of the CTICC, five rooms for every seat in its main auditorium. Rwanda's bureau counts 1,500+ upper-range, 3,500 mid-range and 4,500+ budget rooms nationwide, about 9,500 graded rooms within a national total of 25,000+.

Durban's reports allow a rule of thumb. Its impact studies attribute 0.65 hotel room-nights to each delegate-day in both FY2016/17 and FY2018/19, equivalent to about 2,171 rooms every night of FY2018/19. At that ratio, filling Kigali's 2,600 seats would take about 1,690 rooms a night, against 1,500-plus upper-range rooms in the whole of Rwanda, and the ratio includes local delegates who need no room.

Air access is the other half. Cape Town's guide lists 228 weekly international flights in high season, 156 in low season, and 24 direct international connections on 23 airlines.

> *Filling Kigali's 2,600 seats would take about 1,690 hotel rooms a night, against 1,500-plus upper-range rooms in the whole of Rwanda.*



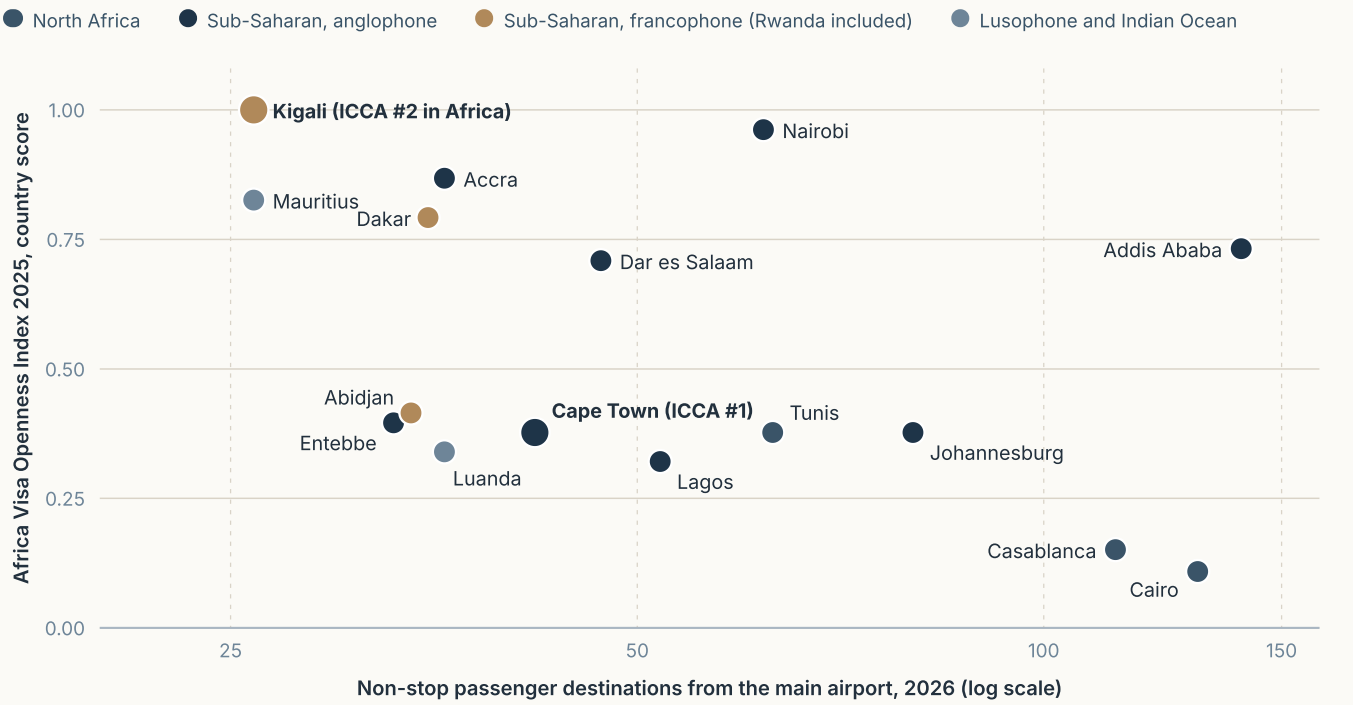
REACH AND ENTRY

Kigali ranks second in Africa from an airport with 26 non-stop destinations

EXHIBIT 17

Addis Ababa, Cairo and Casablanca have the widest route maps in our comparison; Kigali and Nairobi the most open entry

Non-stop destinations from each city's main airport against the country's Africa Visa Openness Index score



Source: FlightConnections route maps as compiled 2026 (single source, grade C); AfDB and African Union, Africa Visa Openness Index 2025; ICCA ranks via Wesgro (21 May 2026) and Rwanda Convention Bureau (May 2025). **Heirstone analysis.**

Addis Ababa (140 non-stop destinations), Cairo (130) and Casablanca (113) are the widest hubs in our comparison, according to FlightConnections route maps. Cairo handled 31.1m passengers in 2025, the most of any African airport, and Casablanca 11.5m. On the Africa Visa Openness Index, which scores entry for African nationals only, Egypt has 0.109 and Morocco 0.151, so event eVisas for named pan-African meetings are the quickest gain open to both.

Rwanda sits at the other corner. It is one of two countries, with The Gambia, that let all Africans in without a visa, and RwandAir serves 18 of Kigali's 26 destinations.

Entry for African travellers matters most for pan-African meetings: AU and AfDB gatherings, Afreximbank annual meetings, the Africa CEO Forum. Associations rotating from Europe or North America face different rules. Cape Town leads Africa's ICCA ranking with 42 destinations and a score of 0.377, which suggests its association business draws on markets the index does not measure, with a reporting venue and a funded bureau behind it.

28%

of intra-African travel scenarios needed no visa in 2025, up from 20% in 2016; 31 countries offered eVisas

1.000

Rwanda's visa-openness score, the maximum, shared only with The Gambia

31.1m

passengers at Cairo in 2025, the most of any African airport, with 130 non-stop destinations

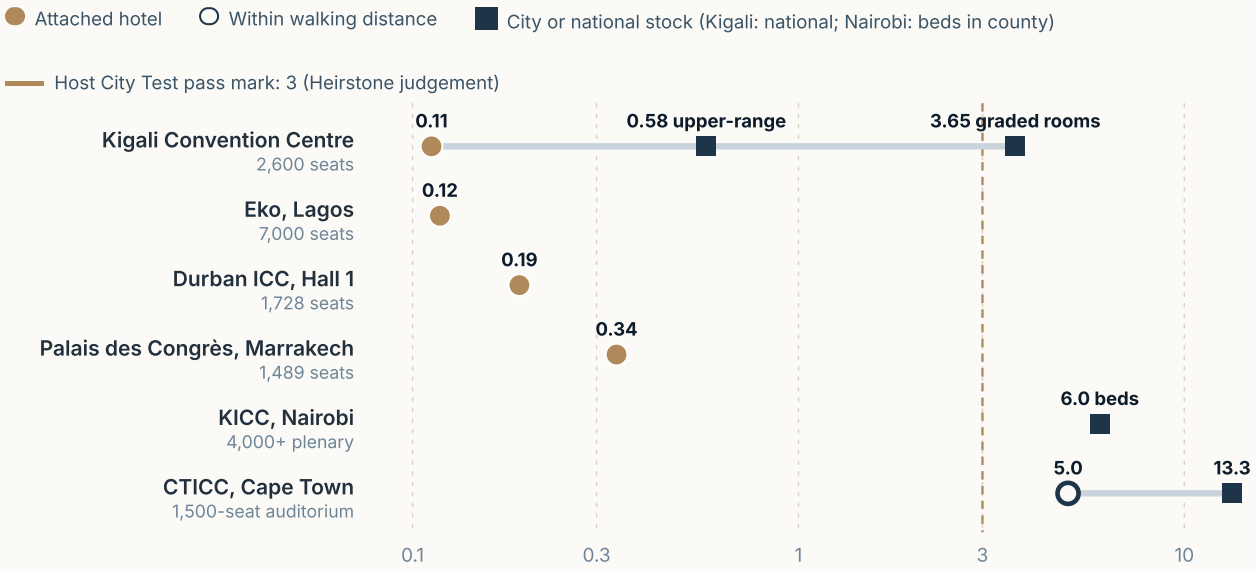
ROOMS AND EVENT SITES

Halls come with a tenth to a third of a hotel room per seat. Summits arrive needing tens of thousands.

EXHIBIT 18

Only Cape Town can show more than three rooms per plenary seat within walking distance

Hotel rooms per seat of the largest hall, by source of rooms (log scale)



Source: AIPC member profile (Kigali Convention Centre); Eko Hotels and Suites; Business Traveller Africa (Hilton Durban); Mövenpick Hotels & Resorts (2016); KICC; Rwanda Convention Bureau fact sheet (c.2025); Tourism Research Institute (Kenya) 2024; Wesgro Meeting Planner's Guide (May 2026); Durban ICC Annual Report 2019. **Heirstone analysis.** Units differ: Nairobi counts beds, Kigali counts the whole country.

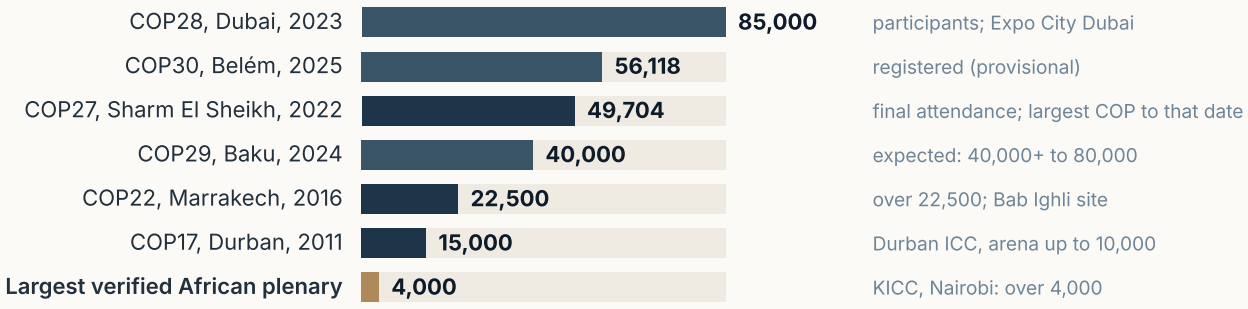
Summit-scale events outgrow permanent halls, in Africa and elsewhere. COP27 brought 49,704 people to Sharm El Sheikh, the largest COP to that date. COP22 drew over 22,500 participants, 15 times the 1,489 seats of the Marrakech Palais, to a dedicated site at Bab Ighli rather than to a permanent hall.

The non-African COPs since then show the same pattern at larger scale. Baku built a dedicated 112,000 m2 venue beside its Olympic Stadium, and Belém registered 56,118 delegates on provisional figures. For summits the binding limit is accommodation, and dedicated event sites supply the floor space.

EXHIBIT 19

Recent climate COPs drew or expected 40,000 to 85,000 people; Africa's largest verified plenary holds over 4,000

Participants at UN climate conferences, latest figure available, and the largest verified permanent plenary in Africa; COP29 at the lower of two published expectations



Source: UNFCCC (COP28); Carbon Brief (COP27, UNFCCC data; COP30, 2025); Euronews and commonspace.eu (COP29, 2024); IISD Earth Negotiations Bulletin (COP22, 2016); Durban ICC Annual Report 2012; KICC (2026).

FRAMEWORK

The Heirstone Host City Test: five gates to clear before a capital commissions a hall

The evidence in this report points to five conditions that decide whether international meetings come to a city and whether its convention centre can pay its way. We turned them into a test. The thresholds are Heirstone judgements, published so that any city can be scored on public evidence and re-scored as the evidence changes.

The test is a screen. It uses only public information, and "not evidenced" earns no pass, because associations, investors and lenders face the same information gap that we do. A government can use it before commissioning a design; a bureau can use it to choose which bids to chase; a hotel investor can read gates 3 and 5 alone.

● pass
◐ partial
○ fail
– not evidenced

1	**Reach** Non-stop destinations from the main airport.	**Threshold.** Pass at 100 or more; partial at 40 to 99; fail below 40.	Delegates rotate from many countries, and every connection adds cost and risk to attendance. Addis Ababa, Cairo and Casablanca pass; Kigali and Cape Town do not.
2	**Entry** Africa Visa Openness Index score of the host country.	**Threshold.** Pass at 0.75 or more; partial at 0.40 to 0.75; fail below 0.40.	Visa friction falls hardest on pan-African meetings, the segment African capitals can most realistically win. It is also the one gate that needs no construction to change.
3	**Rooms** Verified hotel rooms within walking distance of the plenary, or city-wide, per seat of the largest hall.	**Threshold.** Pass at three rooms per seat or more; partial if a lower figure, or only attached or national stock, is published; not evidenced if nothing is published.	Three rooms per seat is about four and a half times Durban's ratio of 0.65 room-nights per delegate-day, enough headroom for congress demand to compete with leisure demand without absorbing the stock.
4	**Venue** A verified plenary of 1,500 seats or more, and published operating results.	**Threshold.** Pass if both; partial if the plenary is verified but results are not published; fail if the largest verified hall is smaller; not evidenced if neither.	Associations and lenders need the same assurance: a hall of congress size, run by an owner that reports how it performs.
5	**Engine** Demand the city does not have to bid for, or a bureau that wins it.	**Threshold.** Pass with an institution that convenes there routinely, an owned annual event, or a bureau with a published bid record and a top-two African ICCA rank; partial with a record of one-off events only.	Recurring demand gives a hall its base load. Nairobi has UNEP, Addis Ababa the AU and UNECA, Abidjan the AfDB, Cairo Afreximbank, Cape Town Mining Indaba and the Africa Energy Forum.

THE TEST APPLIED

None of the twelve cities we tested clears all five gates on public evidence; Cape Town and Nairobi clear three

EXHIBIT 20

Heirstone Host City Test: twelve African meeting cities scored on five gates

Gate result with the evidence used; Reach in non-stop destinations, Entry as AVOI 2025 score; thresholds are Heirstone judgements, set out on the previous page

CITY	1 REACH	2 ENTRY	3 ROOMS	4 VENUE	5 ENGINE	PASSES
Cape Town	◐ 42	○ 0.377	● 7,500 within walk	● CTICC; reports	● Mining Indaba, AEF; bureau	3
Nairobi	◐ 62	● 0.962	◐ 24,151 beds	● KICC 4,000+; audits	● UNEP, UNEA	3
Kigali	○ 26	● 1.000	◐ 9,500 national	◐ KCC 2,600	● ICCA #2; bureau	2
Addis Ababa	● 140	◐ 0.732	– n/v	◐ AU 2,500	● AU, UNECA	2
Cairo	● 130	○ 0.109	– n/v	– n/v	● Afreximbank HQ	2
Dakar	○ 35	● 0.792	– n/v	◐ CICAD 1,500	◐ Francophonie 2014	1
Accra	○ 36	● 0.868	– n/v	◐ Accra ICC 1,600	◐ Afreximbank 2023	1
Abidjan	○ 34	◐ 0.415	– n/v	– n/v	● AfDB headquarters	1
Casablanca and Marrakech	● 113 (CMN)	○ 0.151	◐ 503 attached	○ Palais 1,489	◐ COP22; IMF/WB 2023	1
Johannesburg	◐ 80	○ 0.377	– 9 hotels, rooms n/v	◐ Sandton 4,500 guests	– n/v	0
Lagos	◐ 52	○ 0.321	◐ 824 attached	◐ Eko 7,000 seats	– n/v	0
Tunis	◐ 63	○ 0.377	– n/v	– n/v	– none current	0

Source: FlightConnections (2026, grade C); AfDB and AU, Africa Visa Openness Index 2025; Wesgro (2026); Rwanda Convention Bureau; Tourism Research Institute (Kenya) 2024; UNEP; UNECA; AfDB; Afreximbank; Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark. **Heirstone analysis.** Casablanca and Marrakech are scored together: reach at Casablanca, venue at Marrakech. Afreximbank is headquartered in Cairo, which also hosted the bank's 2022 annual meetings; its 2023 annual meetings were held in Accra.

Cape Town and Nairobi pass three gates each, for different reasons. Cape Town has the rooms, a reporting venue and two owned annual events, and fails on entry for African travellers. Nairobi has the UN′s environment programme, a plenary for over 4,000 with audited accounts and an open visa regime, and needs better evidence on rooms and more routes.

Kigali passes two gates and still ranks second in Africa, which shows what a bid-led bureau and open borders can do with a short route map. Its weak gates, routes and rooms, are the ones that cap growth beyond the current calendar.

The large northern hubs pass on reach, and entry for African travellers is the gate they can change fastest. Cairo and Casablanca each reach more than 100 non-stop destinations and Tunis 63, and Cairo also passes on its demand engine as Afreximbank′s headquarters city.

The most common gap is rooms: 7 of the 12 cities publish no figure for hotel rooms within reach of the plenary. Without it, neither an association nor a hotel investor can size accommodation against the hall.

0 of 12

cities pass all five gates

7 of 12

cities publish no rooms figure that the test can use

CHAPTER 6

06

North Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa

Each country starts from a different position on the five gates. The large northern hubs have the widest reach, and event visas for African travellers are their quickest gain. East Africa scores higher on entry and hosts institutional anchors. West and Central Africa's francophone capitals hold the anchors and summits but are thinner on routes and on published venue data.

EXHIBIT 21

Country snapshot: reach, entry, the largest verified hall and the demand anchor

Non-stop destinations (2026) and passengers (2025, millions) at the main airport; AVOI 2025 country score

COUNTRY	MAIN MEETINGS CITY	NON-STOP DEST.	PAX 2025 (M)	AVOI 2025	LARGEST VERIFIED HALL	ANCHOR OR RECORD
NORTH AFRICA						
Egypt	Cairo; Sharm El Sheikh	130	31.1	0.109	COP27 venue, seats n/v	Afreximbank HQ; COP27 2022; Afreximbank 2022
Morocco	Casablanca; Marrakech	113	11.5	0.151	Palais 1,489	COP22; IMF/WB 2023
Tunisia	Tunis	63	7.4	0.377	n/v	AfDB interim seat 2003-13
Algeria	Algiers	n/c	n/c	n/c	n/v	n/v
SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA, ANGLOPHONE						
South Africa	Cape Town; Johannesburg	42; 80	11.1; 19.7	0.377	Gallagher 7,000 guests	Mining Indaba; AEF
Kenya	Nairobi	62	9.0	0.962	KICC 4,000+	UNEP, UNEA
Ethiopia	Addis Ababa	140	13.1	0.732	AU 2,500	AU, UNECA
Nigeria	Lagos; Abuja	52	7.5	0.321	Eko 7,000 seats	n/v
Ghana	Accra	36	3.6	0.868	Accra ICC 1,600	Afreximbank 2023
Tanzania	Dar es Salaam; Arusha	47	3.0	0.709	AICC 1,350	EAC
Uganda	Kampala	33	2.6	0.396	n/v	n/v
SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA, FRANCOPHONE AND OTHER						
Rwanda	Kigali	26	n/c	1.000	KCC 2,600	ICCA Congress 2027
Côte d'Ivoire	Abidjan	34	2.5	0.415	n/v	AfDB; Africa CEO Forum
Senegal	Dakar	35	2.9	0.792	CICAD 1,500	Francophonie 2014
Cameroon	Yaoundé	n/c	n/c	n/c	Palais 2,000	n/v
DR Congo	Kinshasa	n/c	n/c	n/c	n/v	n/v
Angola	Luanda	36	n/c	0.340	n/v	n/v
Mauritius	Port Louis	26	n/c	0.826	SVICC, seats n/v	n/v

Source: FlightConnections route maps (2026, grade C); FRACS, Air Transport Data Trends Bulletin (2026); AfDB and AU, Africa Visa Openness Index 2025; Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark; UNFCCC; UNEP; UNECA; AfDB; Afreximbank; Ghana Ministry of Finance (2023). n/c: not collected; n/v: not verified. South Africa lists Cape Town and Johannesburg airports separately.

NORTH AFRICA

North Africa has the busiest airports; event visas and published venue data are its quickest gains

Egypt

Cairo's airport handled 31.1m passengers in 2025, the most in Africa, with 130 non-stop destinations. The city is home to Afreximbank's headquarters and hosted the bank's annual meetings in 2022. Greater Cairo had Africa's largest city pipeline of chain hotels in early 2024, 75 hotels and 14,247 rooms, according to W Hospitality Group, and Egypt received about 19 million international tourists in 2025, up 21%. The largest meeting in our data is COP27 at Sharm El Sheikh, where a final attendance of 49,704 made it the largest COP to that date. Egypt has about 228,000 operating hotel rooms, according to Al Arabiya Business, and Alamein, which expected 300,000 tourists in 2026, hosted the second Egypt International Aerospace Show that year, according to Ahram Online.

Cairo's main venues are the Cairo International Conference Centre in Nasr City and the Egypt International Exhibition Center in New Cairo; their specifications were not available from public sources for this edition. A new hall in the New Administrative Capital would be planned alongside them, so its demand test should set out how government, domestic and international business would be shared. The first steps cost little: publish seats, square metres and rooms within reach for the existing venues, and offer event eVisas to African delegates of named pan-African meetings.

Morocco

Casablanca's airport reaches 113 destinations and handled 11.5m passengers in 2025, up 9.3%. Morocco scores 0.151. Marrakech has a thirty-year record of global meetings: the agreement establishing the WTO was concluded there in 1994, the first World Water Forum met there in 1997 with 500 participants, COP22 followed in 2016 and the IMF and World Bank held their Annual Meetings there in 2023, a month after the earthquake. Its Palais des Congrès, with auditoriums seating up to 1,489 and 503 rooms and suites in the attached hotel, reopened in 2016 after a US$100m redevelopment. Under a 2023 plan, part of Casablanca's fair site is to become a congress and exhibition centre with a 5,940 m2 congress hall; the same plan foresees a 5,000-seat congress palace before 2030, according to Médias24.

Morocco's model pairs a hotel-anchored hall for congresses with a dedicated event site for summits.

Egypt and Morocco already hold the reach that most of the continent lacks: Cairo and Casablanca are two of the three widest hubs in our comparison. Published venue specifications and event visas for African delegates would let both turn that reach into more pan-African meetings.

14,247

hotel rooms in Greater Cairo's chain pipeline in early 2024, the largest of any African city

4

global meetings that put Marrakech on the map between 1994 and 2023

Tunisia

The specifications of the Palais des Congrès de Tunis could not be verified. Tunis reaches 63 destinations (7.4m passengers in 2025) and Tunisia scores 0.377. The AfDB operated from Tunis from 2003 to 2013 before returning to Abidjan.

Algeria

Algiers, a city of 2.95m, has the CIC Abdelatif Rahal conference centre. We could verify none of its attributes, and a bid would need to publish them first.

SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA, ANGLOPHONE AND EAST AFRICA

South Africa wins on venues and bureaux, East Africa on open borders and institutions

South Africa

South Africa hosted 98 ICCA meetings in 2023 and 2024 and stayed first in Africa in the 2025 rankings. Stellenbosch, a university town, hosted 10 meetings in the 2025 rankings and ranked 10th in Africa, with 100 between 2013 and 2024. Behind the lead sit two publicly owned venues that report, a funded bureau and owned annual events. Its visa-openness score of 0.377 limits pan-African meetings, and only 2.0% of 2019 foreign tourists gave business as their main purpose.

Kenya

KICC opened in 1973 and its plenary hall holds over 4,000 delegates. Nairobi hosts the UN Environment Assembly, open to all 193 UN member states, at UNEP's headquarters, most recently in 2025: demand it does not have to bid for. Kenya counted 987 international conferences in 2024; Nairobi County has 24,151 hotel beds. With 62 destinations and a 0.962 visa score, Nairobi's priorities are KICC's receivables and a demand test for the planned Bomas complex against KICC.

Ethiopia

Addis Ababa has Africa's widest route map, 140 non-stop destinations, and handled 13.1m passengers in 2025. The AU's 2,500-seat plenary and UNECA's Africa Hall, inaugurated in 1961 and reopened in 2024 after a renovation contracted at US$28.2m, give it institutional demand. Ethiopia scores 0.732. The missing gate is rooms: no hotel stock figure for the city was verified.

Rwanda

Kigali ranked second in Africa for a fifth year in the 2024 rankings, hosted CHOGM in 2022 and the Africa CEO Forum (2,800 participants) in May 2026, and will host the 66th ICCA Congress in 2027, the first in Africa for 23 years. RSSB lists the 2,600-seat centre as a flagship investment. Tourism revenue reached US$647m in 2024, up 4.3%, against a US$1.1bn target for 2029; no meetings revenue line is published. Other governments can match the visa policy without a capital programme; a building at about US$115,000 of complex cost per seat is a separate decision.

Nigeria

The largest verified venue in Lagos, a city of 16.5m, is private and hotel-anchored: Eko Hotels' 824 rooms and conference and banqueting space for 7,000. Lagos airport reaches 52 destinations and grew 13.1% to 7.5m passengers in 2025; Nigeria scores 0.321. The Bureau of Public Enterprises plans a concession for the 322-hectare Lagos International Trade Fair Complex (1976). Data for Abuja's conference centre could not be verified.

Ghana, Tanzania and Mauritius

Accra, whose 1,600-seat conference centre opened in 1991, hosted Afreximbank's annual meetings in 2023; Ghana scores 0.868 but Accra reaches only 36 destinations. Tanzania has Arusha's 1,350-seat AICC and Dar es Salaam's JNICC, a Chinese government grant completed in 2012; it scores 0.709. Mauritius has a 17,000 m2 centre on 53,865 m2 of land, 26 destinations and a 0.826 score: a small-state venue that must import nearly all its demand.

> *Kigali ranks second in Africa from 26 non-stop destinations: open entry and a bid-led bureau have carried it further than its route map would.*

SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA, FRANCOPHONE, AND THE GULF

Francophone capitals hold the anchors and the summits; the Gulf competes for the largest events

Côte d'Ivoire

Abidjan holds the largest institutional anchor in our francophone data, the AfDB's headquarters. The bank operated from Tunis from 2003 to 2013 and returned to Abidjan in 2015, when it had almost 2,000 employees. The Africa CEO Forum, founded in 2012, says its annual summit draws about 2,000 participants from more than 70 countries; its 2026 Kigali edition had 2,800. Abidjan's convention venues, the Hôtel Ivoire among them, could not be verified from public sources for this edition. Abidjan reaches 34 destinations (2.5m passengers); the country scores 0.415.

Senegal

CICAD at Diamniadio, built in eleven months with APIX as delegated project owner, opened for the Francophonie Summit in 2014 with a 1,500-seat hall and 14,700 m2 of enclosed space; its official website was under construction in 2026. Dakar's Blaise Diagne airport reaches 35 destinations (2.9m passengers); Senegal scores 0.792. Entry is open. The gates to close are routes and verified hotel rooms near a hall that sits outside the city.

Cameroon and DR Congo

Yaoundé's Palais des Congrès, inaugurated in 1982, rents rooms of 25 to 2,000 seats, according to Investir au Cameroun; its cost and financing could not be verified. Kinshasa, a city of 17.0m, has the Palais du Peuple, whose capacity and cost could not be verified from public sources for this edition. In both, the first task is published data and an operator.

THE GULF AS COMPETITOR

Dubai hosted COP28 at Expo City Dubai with some 85,000 participants, according to the UNFCCC. Its airport reaches 259 destinations and handled 95.2m passengers in 2025.

Riyadh's Expo 2030 site covers 6m m2, including a 2m m2 gated area, for 42 million expected visits.

Pan-African meetings can leave the continent: the AfDB held its 2017 annual meetings in Gandhinagar, India. For the largest intergovernmental events, North African capitals compete with the Gulf as much as with each other.

EXHIBIT 22

What a capital can count on, and what it has to win

Recurring and rotating meetings relevant to African hosts, with the latest African editions found

MEETING	WHERE	PATTERN	WHAT IT MEANS FOR A HOST CITY
UN Environment Assembly	Nairobi	Recurring	Held at UNEP's headquarters (2025); open to all 193 UN member states; no bid needed
African Union summits	Addis Ababa	Recurring	Fixed at the AU's seat and its 2,500-seat plenary
AfDB headquarters	Abidjan	Permanent	Back from Tunis in 2015 with almost 2,000 employees; a permanent institutional base
Afreximbank headquarters	Cairo	Permanent	Headquartered in Cairo; the bank was founded in 1993
Africa CEO Forum	Kigali, 2026	Yearly	About 2,000 participants a year; 2,800 in Kigali (2026)
Mining Indaba	Cape Town	Every February	Owned annual event at the CTICC; 12,000+ delegates
AfDB Annual Meetings	Rotating	Yearly	Contestable: Gandhinagar, India, 2017
Afreximbank Annual Meetings	Rotating	Yearly	Contestable: Cairo 2022, Accra 2023
IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings	Rotating	Periodic	Nairobi 1973 and Marrakech 2023, fifty years apart
UN climate COP	Rotating	Yearly	Recent African hosts: Durban 2011, Marrakech 2016, Sharm El Sheikh 2022
CHOGM	Rotating	Periodic	African hosts include Durban 1999 and Kigali 2022
ICCA Congress	Kigali, 2027	Yearly, rotating	Won by bid; first in Africa for 23 years

Source: UNEP (2025); African Union (2012); AfDB, History page; Afreximbank website; Ghana Ministry of Finance (2023); Government of India, PIB (2017); Africa CEO Forum and Mining Indaba websites; KICC history; IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings 2023 site; UNFCCC; Durban ICC; Commonwealth Secretariat (CHOGM 2022); Rwanda Convention Bureau (2025).

CHAPTER 7

What each party should do

07

GOVERNMENTS, INVESTMENT PROMOTION AGENCIES AND TOURISM AUTHORITIES

1 **Run the Host City Test before the design competition.**

Score the candidate city on reach, entry, rooms, venue and demand engine with public evidence, and fix failing gates first. CICAD, the AU centre and KCC were each built to a summit date; the test asks the market question before that date is set.

2 **Open entry for African delegates before adding seats.**

Rwanda ranks second in Africa from 26 routes with a score of 1.000. Egypt and Morocco, with two of the three widest hubs we compared, stand to gain most from event eVisas for named pan-African meetings. Visa waivers or event eVisas cost less than any building.

3 **Size the permanent hall to the association market and plan dedicated sites for summits.**

Verified plenaries cluster at about 1,500 to 2,600 seats. Summits arrive with 22,500 to 85,000 people. Build divisible flat floor, which cost Durban about US$2,500 a seat at 2024 rates against a complex cost of about US$115,000 per seat at Kigali, and plan a dedicated event site for summits, as Marrakech did at Bab Ighli for COP22.

4 **Put the full public cost in the budget.**

Land, rates, depreciation and debt service belong in the case alongside EBITDA. Durban's rates-linked impairment of R57.6m turned a profit into a loss in FY2017/18. Publish annual accounts and impact methods to CTICC and Durban standards.

GOVERNMENTS, CONTINUED

5 **Separate the owner of the building from the operator.**

Use concessions or management contracts with targets for international events and delegate-days, as Cape Town (stake sale, land retained) and Nigeria (Lagos Trade Fair concession) have proposed. Ministries that book state venues should pay on time; KICC's receivables overdue by three years or more equalled 61% of its FY2018/19 revenue.

CONVENTION BUREAUS

6 **Report international delegate-days alongside conference counts.**

Publish ICCA-definition counts beside national statistics, with average delegates and days. Kenya's 987 conferences at 38 international delegates and Cape Town's 58 meetings at 717 describe different markets.

7 **Publish a rooms register for the venue precinct.**

Rooms within walking distance and within 15 minutes, by grade. Seven of the twelve cities we tested publish no usable figure; Cape Town's 7,500 within walking distance is the reference.

8 **Chase rotations that return.**

Target pan-African institutional annual meetings, which rotate and can leave Africa (the AfDB in Gandhinagar, India, 2017), and help sectors build owned annual events on the Mining Indaba model.

WHAT EACH PARTY SHOULD DO, CONTINUED

VENUE OWNERS AND OPERATORS

9 Manage to the international share.

At Durban an international event earns about 11 times a national one. Set targets for international events and delegate-days, and report them with the forward book, as CTICC does with about 400 events booked to FY2029/30.

10 Price for yield.

CTICC raised revenue 44% in a year with fewer events, lifting revenue per event to R1.09m. The mix of events moved revenue more than the number of events did.

HOTEL INVESTORS AND LENDERS

11 Underwrite rooms from delegate-days.

Use about 0.65 room-nights per delegate-day as a floor, from Durban's two reported years, and apply it to a venue's dated forward book. Summit peaks are one-offs and should not set the base case.

12 Pay for proximity.

Cape Town has 7,500 of its roughly 20,000 rooms within walking distance of the CTICC. Attached hotels in the benchmark offer only 0.11 to 0.34 rooms per seat, which leaves the walkable precinct as the investable gap.

13 Do not let a venue become a hotel subsidy.

US cities that over-built later financed headquarters hotels and room-night rebates. In the US cases, hotel subsidies followed venues built ahead of demand.

DEVELOPMENT FINANCE INSTITUTIONS, PENSION FUNDS AND ASSET MANAGERS

14 Value the operating business at operating multiples.

Cape Town's own valuation implies about 15 times EBITDA and US$69m for Africa's best documented convention business, against US$200m to US$300m build costs for recent flagship complexes. Lend against the concession, with availability or minimum-revenue terms from the public owner.

15 Ask pension-backed venues for the same disclosure as listed assets.

Where public pension capital is invested in a hall, as RSSB reports for Kigali, members are owed occupancy, revenue and yield figures. None were found for KCC.

COMPANIES AND INSTITUTIONS THAT CONVENE IN AFRICA

16 Choose host cities by the five gates.

For regional meetings that bring staff and clients from across Africa, entry and reach decide attendance. Addis Ababa, Cairo and Casablanca score well on reach; Nairobi, Kigali, Accra and Dakar on entry.

THE BOTTOM LINE

New African flagship complexes have cost US$80,000 to US$115,000 per plenary seat. The seat earns its keep only when delegates can reach the city and sleep near the hall, and when the hall wins international events. Governments that secure those conditions first can size their halls to the association market and fill them more often.

WHO CONTROLS EACH GATE OF THE HOST CITY TEST

1 Reach	2 Entry	3 Rooms	4 Venue	5 Engine
Governments through air service agreements; airlines and airport operators	Governments: visa policy, event eVisas and waivers for named meetings	Hotel investors and lenders; land agencies that zone plots within walking distance of the venue	Owners and operators, under concessions with published targets and accounts	Convention bureaus, host institutions and sector event organisers

NOTES, SOURCES AND DEFINITIONS

How we built the numbers

Definitions

ICCA meeting: an international association meeting that rotates between at least three countries and draws at least 50 delegates. ICCA's country and city counts are restricted to members; African figures here come from bureau releases and the press. **International conference (Kenya):** the Tourism Research Institute's national category; delegates reported are international delegates only. **Delegate-day:** one delegate attending for one day, as reported by venues. **EBITDA** (CTICC) excludes depreciation of the buildings; Durban ICC reports net profit or loss after depreciation, impairment and tax, so the two are compared within each venue, not across. **Cost per seat:** reported construction or renovation cost divided by the largest room's capacity; scopes differ, and the Kigali and AU figures cover whole complexes, Kigali's with a hotel and an office park. **Rooms per seat:** attached, walking-distance or wider room counts divided by the largest room's capacity. **AVOI:** the AfDB and African Union Africa Visa Openness Index, 0 to 1, measuring openness to African nationals only.

Method

Heirstone Convention Centre Benchmark. A register of 31 named African convention, conference and exhibition venues in 18 countries, of which 20 have at least one verified attribute (19 from the register plus UNECA's Africa Hall). Figures come from venue and operator websites and reports, Kenya's Auditor-General, AidData, official releases and the press, as listed below. Nothing was estimated where data were missing; positions on the map are GeoNames locality centres. **Heirstone Host City Test.** Five gates with the thresholds set out in Chapter 5. The thresholds are Heirstone judgements, not industry standards. Cities are scored only on public evidence; "not evidenced" is scored as such and not as a fail. **Exchange rates.** Rand: US Treasury reporting rates of R14.168 (30 June 2019), R18.936 (30 June 2023), R18.194 (30 June 2024) and R17.757 (30 June 2025) per US$, applied to the financial year ending on that date; Durban figures before FY2018/19 are left in rand. Durban arena cost and Bomas: World Bank 2024 average rates (R18.33 and KES 134.82 per US$), which are not build-year rates and understate original US$ costs where currencies have since weakened. KICC: KES 102.24 (30 June 2019). RSSB real estate: RWF 1,450 (30 September 2026). The rand lost about 20% of its US$ value between June 2019 and June 2025; rand series overstate dollar growth. **Source conflicts.** Cape Town's 55 meetings is taken as the 2025 rankings count (Wesgro's release says "in 2024", while IOL reported 58 for 2024). Durban's FY2020/21 revenue is R10.4m in one report and R20.4m in the next; it is not used. COP27 attendance is given as the final 49,704; provisional registration was 33,449. Durban's arena cost R460m according to the press at its opening; the venue's history gives R395m for the expansion project. Hilton Durban has 327 rooms in Business Traveller Africa and 328 in AMI; we use 327. COP29 attendance was expected at over 40,000 (Euronews) or 80,000 (commonspace.eu); the lower figure is charted.

Sources by chapter

1 A small market. ICCA: GlobeWatch Country and City Rankings 2025 release; Annual Country and City Rankings Report for 2023; African Chapter page; 2025 Global Government Meetings Intelligence Report. Wesgro: ICCA 2025 rankings release (21 May 2026); Convention Bureau home page; Meeting Planner's Guide (May 2026). IOL (4 June 2025). Rwanda Convention Bureau: press releases (March and May 2025) and MICE fact sheet. Tourism Research Institute (Kenya): Tourism Sector Performance Report 2024. Statistics South Africa: Tourism 2019. Carbon Brief: COP27 delegates analysis. Mining Indaba and Africa CEO Forum websites. UNFCCC: COP22 and COP28 pages. IISD Earth Negotiations Bulletin: COP22 summary.

2 What a meeting pays. CTICC: Integrated Annual Reports 2019/20 and 2022; AGM releases (25 January 2022, 19 February 2024, 27 January 2025); address at the official opening (28 June 2003). Durban ICC: Annual Reports 2012, 2015, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2021, 2022 and 2023; Economic Impact page.

NOTES, SOURCES AND DEFINITIONS, CONTINUED

Sources by chapter, continued

3 Who carries the building. KT Press (2016); The East African (2016); Construction Review Online (2014); AIPC member profile (Kigali Convention Centre); African Union, AU Conference Center inauguration release (2012); Mövenpick Hotels & Resorts (2016); Sowetan (2007); Durban ICC, history page; Construction Kenya (2025); AidData (JNICC). RSSB investment page. IOL Weekend Argus (21 August 2025). Office of the Auditor-General (Kenya): KICC reports FY2018/19 to FY2022/23. H. Sanders, Space Available, Brookings Institution (January 2005). Bureau of Public Enterprises (Nigeria): Lagos International Trade Fair Complex (2019, 2021).

4 Benchmark. Venue and operator websites (CTICC, KICC, AICC, SVICC, Gallagher, Southern Sun, Eko Hotels and Suites); News Ghana (2026); Au Sénégal and APIX (CICAD); Investir au Cameroun (2016); UNECA (Africa Hall); Médias24 (2023); World Bank WDI SP.URB.TOTL and EN.URB.LCTY (2024) and PA.NUS.FCRF; GeoNames; Natural Earth.

5 The constraint outside the hall. FlightConnections route maps (2026); AfDB and African Union, Africa Visa Openness Index 2025; FRACS, Air Transport Data Trends Bulletin (2026); Carbon Brief (COP30, 2025); Euronews and commonspace.eu (COP29, 2024); UNEP; Afreximbank; Business Traveller Africa (Hilton Durban); Wesgro; Rwanda Convention Bureau; Durban ICC.

6 Regions. As above, plus EUR-Lex (WTO Agreement, 1994); World Water Council; IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings 2023 site; AfDB, History page; Ghana Ministry of Finance (2023); Government of India, PIB (2017); Commonwealth Secretariat (CHOGM 2022); Expo 2030 Riyadh Company; Government of Dubai Media Office (2026); Al Arabiya Business (2025); Ahram Online (2026); Rwanda Development Board. W Hospitality Group, Hotel Chain Development Pipelines in Africa 2024 (March 2024). Ecofin Agency, Egypt tourist arrivals (6 January 2026).

What we could not find

The gaps are themselves a finding. ICCA counts were public only for Cape Town, Stellenbosch and South Africa, with ranks for Kigali and Rwanda. No financing terms, occupancy or operating results were found for the Kigali Convention Centre, and no build cost for the CTICC, KICC, CICAD or the Sharm El Sheikh venue. City hotel stock was verified only for Cape Town and Nairobi (beds), with a national figure for Rwanda. No independent ex-post impact study was found for CHOGM 2022, COP22, COP27 or the 2023 IMF and World Bank meetings, and no African study of delegate spend per day. Venue attributes for Abidjan, Abuja, Algiers, Cairo, Gaborone, Kinshasa, Luanda and Tunis, Rwanda's meetings revenue and national bid-support schemes could not be verified. CTICC's FY2024/25 and Durban's FY2023/24 and FY2024/25 reports exist but could not be retrieved.

Grades and caveats

Figures that rest on a single secondary source are attributed in the text or graded C in the tables, including the Bomas tender value, Egypt's hotel room count, the COP29 expected attendance and the FlightConnections route counts. Costs are nominal and not inflation-adjusted. Bureau and venue impact figures are reported as published and are not net additional impact.

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